

THE FOES From left, Manu Rishi Chadha as Pervez Musharraf, Vinay Pathak as Nawaz Sharif, Danish Husain as Javed Hassan

War action dramas never get old, but when it comes to real stories of bravery and spirit, the events largely unfold on the ground. Rarely have the other two branches of the Indian military—the air force and the navy—got their moment in the limelight. And when they have, on the big screen, they've failed to take off at the box office—like the recent aerial action titles *Tejas* (2023) and *Fighter* (2024). Netflix's *Operation Safed Sagar* fills the void for the small screen by shining a light on the heroics of the Indian Air Force (IAF) in daunting heights during the 1999 Kargil War. For the platform, the six-episode series is a prestige title much like *Heeramandi* (2024), not just for its ambitious scale but also for the daring of the creators and the freshness of the narrative.

"Safed Sagar is the IAF's most significant chapter from the recent past, their landmark win which needs to be narrated," says Tanya Bami, series head, Netflix India. "It is a special one for us, not just for this year but because it earmarks our tenth year in India." While it is a big-scale production, the show, assures Bami, "takes you into the lives of the officers and the challenges they face". Made with the IAF's cooperation, Bami singles it out as a title that necessitated both "responsibility and respect" in storytelling and "passion".

These facets came from co-creator and writer Abhijeet Singh Parmar, who, alongside former IAF officer Kushal Srivastava, devoted years to research by meeting nearly 50-60 IAF personnel to grasp the significance of the mission. "Detail and authenticity were front and centre," adds Bami, "right from the width of the valleys between which the planes had to fly." It also involved the production design team building photorealistic cockpit shells mounted on hydraulic rigs, with IAF pilots briefing the actors on how to sit and move inside them.

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That attention to detail extends to the dialogue, which is peppered with Air Force lingo. "It has to feel immersive and real," says Parmar. "One has to convey what is being said without losing the specificity of how they talk." For Parmar, it was equally important that audiences get a peek into the IAF culture and mentality. "It's the force that has the best sense of humour," he says.

The IAF didn't just offer details of the operation, but opened up its stations to the crew for shoots and had its pilots fly MiG-21s